

everyday life, such as a woman in childbirth and a baby crying.

- The **unique selling point** is the ‘showing’ of the athletes’ stories. There is no voice-over and no graphics moralising on the plight of the disabled. Instead, there is an attempt to give a realistic portrayal of the lives of disabled athletes. The audience are left towards the end of the advertisement with the words ‘To be a Paralympian there’s got to be something wrong with you’, encouraging them to examine their own misconceptions of disability in the light of what they have just viewed.
- The advertisement was successful in reaching its audience. Channel 4’s Paralympic coverage was viewed by 20 million people, a third of the UK population, 22% of whom were 16-34 years of age. The marketing campaign reached 81% of the UK population. The Paralympic Games attracted 2.6 million viewers accounting for the biggest Channel 4 weekly share of TV viewing since 2016 and the largest daytime share since 2012 (<https://www.channel4.com/press/news/channel-4s-coverage-tokyo-2020-paralympic-games-reaches-20-million-viewers>).

Consider how audiences may interpret this advertisement in different ways.

- The *Super. Human.* advertisement sets out to challenge audiences’ perceptions of disability.
- Regular audiences of Channel 4 may be familiar with the approach taken by the broadcaster when promoting the Paralympics as the other two campaigns were successes in their own right. Alex Brooker, co-presenter of *The Last Leg*, who has disabilities himself, said: “For me, waiting for the Channel 4 Paralympics advert every four years is like waiting for the John Lewis Christmas advert.”
- Audiences would expect the advertisement to raise the profile of the event. Zaid Al-Qassab, chief marketing officer of Channel 4, said of the thinking behind the campaign, ‘The Paralympics has always been an afterthought of the Olympics. It was the first time that any broadcaster was making a meaningful attempt to elevate the

Paralympics on an equal footing. And the only way of doing that was to land it in public consciousness through something that would make you sit up and think totally differently.’ (<https://www.campaignlive.co.uk/article/theyve-nailed-again-channel-4-unveils-super-human-campaign-tokyo-paralympics/1722076>)

- The advertisement may make some audiences feel uncomfortable as it uses shock tactics to make audiences aware of the issues facing disabled people in their sport as well as in their everyday lives. For example, time lapse photography is used to show a bruise developing and there is a close-up shot of a blister being popped. Audiences may also be affected by seeing disabled rugby player Kylie Grimes unable to enter a café as her wheelchair cannot get over the step.
- The advertisement also challenged audiences to examine how they may use outdated language to categorise disabled people by the on-screen slogan at the end of the advertisement ‘To be a Paralympian there’s got to be something wrong with you’. The aim of this is to encourage audiences to see this as something positive and that being a Paralympian is something of which to be proud.

CONTEXTS

Social and Cultural

- Advertising campaigns, whether for consumable products, events or charities, reflect the concerns and issues of the society that produces them. In promoting the Paralympics and creating the trailer, Channel 4 is seeking to address the under-representation or misrepresentation of a particular social group.
- The advertisement seeks to focus on the fact that these are real people – ‘Human’ rather than ‘Super’ – which makes them more accessible to the audience.
- The representation of disability in this advertisement is affected by social and cultural circumstances. Channel 4 has taken the active decision to present the athletes neither as victims or as heroes, but just ordinary sports men and